minister told me. Being pushed to Rashtrapati Bhavan as a near-consensus candidate was scant compensation.

That move also ended any chance Dr Singh may have had of easing himself out into a more comfortable environment. In any case, he had always been a great survivor. For the last two years of his political career, that's all he was—a survivor. In those two years, there was more dirt, more scandal, and more of his ministers had to resign. One of them, law minister Ashwani Kumar, had to resign amidst allegations that he had tried to 'protect' the prime minister by making changes in the status report of the CBI on the coal block allocations. Kumar was seen as a 'Manmohan man' and later insisted to me that he was made a scapegoat. Dr Singh's office was even accused of allowing crucial coal files to go missing. Through it all, Dr Singh hung on to the chair. But as one Opposition MP pointed out, 'Yes, the patient is breathing, but *yeh bhi koi jeena hai* [is this any way to live]!'

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On 3 January 2014, just months before the general elections, Dr Singh announced at a press conference before the national media that he was 'retiring' from politics after the elections and he would not be in the race for prime minister. It was an unprecedented move—no Indian prime minister had publicly 'retired' before an election. Just months earlier, Rahul Gandhi had publicly snubbed the prime minister by rejecting the Cabinet's ordinance on criminal MPs. There were reports that Dr Singh had contemplated stepping down in protest and his family had suggested that he just walk away. When I later asked him about it, his response was, 'But the ordinance was a collective decision of the government, not just mine alone.' So was he angry with Rahul and had he ever thought of resigning at the time? He stayed silent and then urged me to have my coffee. We were alone in his room. The loneliness of a defeated man filled the air.

In fact, I have confirmed with a source close to Dr Singh that he did, indeed, once again offer to resign after Rahul tore up the government ordinance. Dr Singh told Sonia he'd had enough. 'Let me go now, madam. I